Reformer Assessment Class

45 minutes · teacher training assessment

REFORMER – 45 MIN – FULL BODY
PROPS: SMALL SOFT BALL PER REFORMER, SHOULDER-REST BLOCKS, KNEE PAD, WEDGE ON HAND

RUNNING CLOCK

CLOCK	SEGMENT	TIME	SPRING	FOOTBAR
0:00	Intro & screening	2 min	–	–
2:00	Warm-up – footwork & bridges	5.5 min	RR	Up
7:30	Section 1 – Core, hands in straps	7 min	R – the only change	Up (carried)
14:30	Section 2a – Legs, first side	5.5 min	R (carried)	Up
20:00	Section 3 – Core, plank family	6 min	R (carried)	Up
26:00	Section 2b – Legs, second side	5.5 min	R (carried)	Up
31:30	Section 4 – Back chain & arms	8 min	R (carried)	Down
39:30	Cooldown	4.5 min	R (carried)	Down
44:00	Outro	1 min	–	–
45:00	**End**	**45 min exactly**	**1 spring change**	**1 bar change**

*Two checkpoints to memorise: start the **second leg side at 26:00**, start the **cooldown at 39:30**. Behind at either? Drop Section 4's three optional exercises first, then cut reps there – never in the second leg side, never in the cooldown.*

SPRING PLAN

RR (warm-up) → **R** (everything else: core / straps, legs, plank block, back, cooldown)
One spring change, well under the maximum of three. The call at 7:30: "take one red off – one red only, and that's the only change today. Footbar stays up." One bar change at 31:30 (bar down for the back block), with no spring change attached – Section 1 uses the raised bar as the leg-extension target.

Load is managed with range and position rather than springs. In the back block, everyone sits closer to the straps, since one red is heavy for arm work. Fallback if the room is mostly beginners or several people flag shoulders: a blue at 31:30 with the bar change (still only two changes).

The ball is held in the arms (footwork, lunges), threaded under the tabletop leg, squeezed between the knees (Bridges, plank block) and held high between the thighs through the back block.

INTRO AND SCREENING: 2 MIN

Keep it tight, but don't skip it – it's a scored item and the safety basis for everything that follows.

> *"Hi everyone, I'm [name] – welcome in. Quick check before we start: anyone brand new to Reformer? Anyone pregnant, or working around an injury – back, shoulder, wrist, knee? Hand up or catch my eye and I'll tell you exactly what to set and give you an option. You're changing your own springs today – there's only one change, I'll call it out loud and show you on mine, so nothing to work out on your own. Grab a small ball for your reformer too – we'll use it all class. We've got kneeling and standing on the carriage today, so if knees are sensitive grab a pad now."*

Breath / Centering – gives students a moment to arrive before the first cue.

Screening flags to carry through the class:

FLAG	WHERE IT MATTERS	ACTION
Pregnancy	Section 1 core (supine), both leg sides, plank block	Shorten supine work, wedge under the shoulders, reduce spring, substitute bridges with a side-lying option
Wrist	Whole plank block, Elephant, Down Stretch, the optional Mountain Climber	Fists instead of flat palms, or forearms on the plank/push-up
Shoulder	Section 1 straps block, Section 4 back block (both on one red), Long Stretch, push-up	Sit closer to the straps in Section 4, keep the High Row elbows low, skip the optional Reverse Fly, small press (or none) on the Press Up, push-up from knees
Knee	Scooter, Down Stretch, high kneeling in the back block, standing quad stretch, ball squeeze	Knee pad, shorter range, carriage closer to home; ball between the thighs rather than at the knee; keep the quad stretch shallow and hold the frame
Low back	Bridges and bridge press-out, Roll Up, Section 1 leg extensions & scissors, Hundred, Down Stretch	Smaller bridge range and a small press-out, no Roll Up (roll to the side and press up), stay in the over-the-bar set only, legs higher in the Hundred, less extension in Down Stretch

WHY THE LEGS ARE SPLIT

The lower-body block is split in half with the core / plank block between the two sides (Section 2a → Section 3 → Section 2b). Three reasons, worth saying out loud if the assessor asks:

- **Recovery for the shoulder girdle.** Down Stretch, Long Stretch, push-up and the two Elephants are five consecutive wrist- and shoulder-loaded exercises, and Section 4 is eight minutes of pulling. The second leg side gives the upper body a real break before it has to row.
- **Zero transition cost.** Every junction matches the position either side of it: Flying Lunge (hands on bar) → Down Stretch (kneeling, hands on bar), then One-Leg Elephant (standing, hands on bar) → Long Lunge (standing). Nothing is jolted.
- **Zero spring cost.** Everything from Section 1 onwards sits on one red, so the split spends none of the change budget.

WARM-UP – FOOTWORK AND BRIDGES: 5.5 MIN

Spring: RR (footbar up)
Lying supine – feet on the footbar, hip-width, ball held in the arms for the footwork. Dynamic only, no static holds. All three planes: sagittal throughout, transverse in the Pilates V, frontal in the ball squeeze that runs through the bridges. Order: two legs to one, then feet to hips – the ball moves only once, from the arms to the knees.

- Leg Press – Pilates V, balls of the feet, heels touching, toes apart, ball held over the chest x 8 (transverse + sagittal)
    - Small pulses near straight legs, knees soft x 8
- Leg Press – toes on the bar, parallel, hip width, ball in the arms x 8
    - Small pulses near straight legs x 8
- Heel Raises – same foot position, legs straight, holding the ball x 6 full range
    - Small pulses at the top x 6
- Prances, holding the ball x 20 alternating – slow and even, then quicker and lighter
- Double Leg Press – balls of the feet, parallel, hip width, ball in the arms x 8, slow return
    - 3 counts out, 3 counts home to advance
- Single Leg Extension – one foot stays on the bar, other leg to tabletop, find neutral first x 6 each side
    - *Option 1:* press the carriage out and thread the ball under the tabletop leg, hand to hand – knee stays at tabletop
    - *Option 2:* extend the leg long over the footbar as the carriage comes in, bend the knee back as you press away – flexed toes, heel pressing into the bar
    - Knee slightly past tabletop if the ball won't thread; don't let the hip grip
- Glute Bridge – heels on the footbar, ball between the knees, arms long
    - Find neutral first: tuck, arch, settle in the middle, a few ball squeezes there
    - Articulating x 3 – squeeze the ball at the top and hold the squeeze all the way back down to neutral; ribs wrap towards the hips, no pelvic thrust
    - Small lift and lower x 8, squeezing the ball each lift – glutes and hamstrings keep the carriage parked
- Glute Bridge 2, press out & return – hips high, press the carriage away and pull it back in x 6
    - Hips lower an inch or two as the carriage goes out, lift as it comes in; ball squeezed throughout, knees tracking over the middle toes
    - Then park the carriage: small pulses x 6 → hold the squeeze, lower 10% and lift x 6 → hold, breath in, roll down
    - Small press, or lower the hips between reps to regress · slower return to advance
- Pilates Roll Up – ball down, legs long x 4, the last one stays seated
    - Bent knees with hands behind the thighs, or a half roll-back, to regress · slower down phase to advance
    - No roll up for pregnancy, low back or osteoporosis – roll to the side and press up to sitting

The last Roll Up finishes seated – the spring change happens there. The room changes its own spring, so call it from your own reformer and let everyone see the colour, then walk and check. Footbar stays up, because Section 1 extends the legs over and under it. One stop, not two.

> *Pre-cue: "Last roll up – stay sitting at the top. Spring change: take one red off. One red only, and that's the only change today. Footbar stays up. Then roll back down and take your straps, and I'll check as I come round."*

SECTION 1 — CORE, HANDS IN STRAPS: 7 MIN

Spring: R (the only change — footbar up)
Supine, straps in hands, arms above the shoulders. One red asks more of the shoulders than a blue — regress with a smaller arm range and head down, not a lighter spring.

- Arm Press Down x 8 – head stays down, this one is just the arms
    - Feet flat on the carriage to regress · legs to tabletop to advance
- Abdominal Curl x 8 – press the arms down and curl the head and chest up on the same breath
    - Arms and curl move together, arms stay long, no bending at the elbow
    - Feet on the carriage, head down, press only, to regress · legs to tabletop to advance
- Curl + Single Leg Extension x 6 each side → Double Leg Extension x 6
    - Curl and hold; extend one leg at a time, then both together. Only the leg travels – the pelvis doesn't rock
    - Head down, or single leg only, to regress · lower the legs to advance
- Set 1 – over → under the bar → hold → legs only → Scissors → return
    - Curl + Double Leg Extension **over** the footbar x 4 – higher, kinder on the low back
    - Double Leg Extension **under** the footbar x 4 – lower, harder work
    - Hold the extension, then legs only – bend and extend x 4, arms and curl stay still
    - Scissors, all the way up and all the way down x 4 each side, then bend the knees and return
    - Stay over the bar, head down, smaller scissor to regress
- Set 2 – extend → hold → Tricep Press → hold → Flutter Kick → return
    - Curl + Double Leg Extension, hold. Tricep Press in the hold x 6 – elbows bend and straighten, upper arms still, elbows pointing to the footbar
    - Hold again, then Flutter Kick x 20 beats – small and quick, the flutter is at the hips
    - Head down, legs higher, or tricep press with the feet on the carriage to regress · lower legs, slower tricep press to advance
- Hundred x 100 beats – straight in from the flutter kick, no rest
    - Legs to tabletop or head down to regress · legs to 45° to advance

The section opens with the Arm Press Down: a simple sagittal shoulder movement that lets everyone find the straps, the spring and a stable ribcage with the head still down. The Abdominal Curl adds the curl to that same press, so the first two exercises are one movement built in two steps — arms, then arms plus spine. No rotation and no arm circles: the neck is loaded the whole way through, so the time goes into the curl and the legs, and the transverse plane is already covered in the Pilates V, the Flying Lunge and the rows.

*Set 1 and Set 2 are the same shape — curl, extend, hold — and the hold is where each set adds its layer. Set 1 adds movement at the **hips** (legs only, then the full scissor); Set 2 adds it at the **arms** (the tricep press) and then a faster, smaller leg beat. Each set ends with a deliberate return, which gives the neck a break and stops the whole thing turning into one long hold.*

Roll up to seated, step off to the side. No spring change, no bar change — say "same spring, one red" out loud so nobody reaches for a spring out of habit.

SECTION 2A – LEGS, FIRST SIDE: 5.5 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar up)
Standing foot on the floor next to the carriage, back foot against the shoulder rest. Run all four on one side, then leave it – the second side is Section 2b. Ball in the arms for the Long Lunge and Scooter; put it down before the Flying Lunge.

- Long Lunge, ball held at the chest, no reach x 8
    - Lunge + reach the ball up overhead x 8
    - 1 lunge, 1 ball pass under the front thigh, return x 6
    - Lunge hold, ball passing only x 8
    - Shorter range, back knee resting on the carriage, or hold the ball still, to regress
- Scooter, ball held at the chest, pressing straight back x 8
    - Press back + 1 standing-heel raise each rep x 8
    - Hold the back leg long, heel raises only x 8
    - Ball down, hands on the bar, heel stays down to regress
- Flying Lunge – knee tuck, ball down, hands on the bar x 10
    - Foot stays on the ground to regress · lift the flying leg higher to advance
- Flying Lunge – knee left / right / centre x 6 cycles (transverse / frontal)
    - A direct progression of the tuck – same shape, zero transition

Four exercises in 5.5 minutes – the extra sets and the holds fill the time rather than a fifth exercise. Allow about 15 seconds across the block for set-up between exercises. One red is the looser, less stable setting, so the standing work is wobblier and asks more of balance and deep core: regress with range, or ball down and hands on the bar – never by adding spring.

Foot down, step onto the carriage and kneel, then pick up the ball and set it between the knees for Down Stretch. No spring change, no bar change, keep talking.

SECTION 3 – CORE, PLANK FAMILY: 6 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar up)
Five consecutive wrist- and shoulder-loaded exercises. Offer fists or forearms **before** the first one, not after someone is uncomfortable. The ball stays between the knees from Down Stretch through the push-up – the squeeze switches on the adductors and deep core and keeps the legs as one line – and comes out for both Elephants.

- Down Stretch, ball between the knees x 8
    - Smaller extension, chest lifted less to regress · full range, longer carriage travel to advance
- Long Stretch, ball between the knees x 6 – straight out of Down Stretch, no re-set
    - Knees down to regress (that is Down Stretch, and it is the same work) · longer press to advance
- Plank, ball between the knees, hold x 3 breaths → Push-up x 8
    - Knees down to regress · slower lowering to advance
- Elephant, ball down x 8
    - Soft knees, smaller carriage travel to regress · heels down, longer range to advance
- One-Leg Elephant stretch, ball down, spine neutral x 5 each side
    - Shoulders square and level – no hitching up on the lifted-leg side
    - Lifted foot stays low to regress · longer carriage travel to advance

Down Stretch is the only spinal extension in the class. It opens the block, so the spine is lengthened before the flexion-heavy plank work. Do not cut it.

From standing at the bar after the One-Leg Elephant, pick the ball up and set up for the second leg side.

> *Pre-cue: "Step off to the side – back to the legs, other side this time. Same springs, nothing to change."*

SECTION 2B – LEGS, SECOND SIDE: 5.5 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar up)
Repeat Section 2a in full on the second side, same reps, same layers.

- Long Lunge, ball at the chest x 8 + reach the ball up x 8 + 1 lunge, 1 pass x 6 + lunge hold, passing only x 8
- Scooter with ball, straight back x 8 + heel raise x 8 + hold, heel raises only x 8
- Flying Lunge – knee tuck, ball down x 10
- Flying Lunge – knee left / right / centre x 6 cycles

Teach this side differently: the exercises are already known, so cut the set-up cueing roughly in half and spend the recovered time walking, observing and adjusting. This is the single best window for the Observation, Hands-on adjustments and Active teaching criteria – five and a half minutes where nobody needs you to explain anything. Mark the music change here.

From the Flying Lunge, step off to the side. Bar down, spring stays on one red. Then kneel up facing the straps, ball high between the thighs, and cross the ropes.

> *Pre-cue: "Footbar down. Spring stays on one red – after this, nothing on your reformer moves again. Grab your ball and come onto the carriage – I'll set you up from the top."*

SECTION 4 – BACK CHAIN AND ARMS: 8 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar down, the only bar change)
High kneeling facing the straps for the whole block, **ball held high between the thighs** – the squeeze squares the pelvis, stops the hips swinging in the rows, and is what lets the single-arm rotation stay in the spine instead of the hips. Ropes crossed for the three rows, then uncrossed for everything after – not a spring change. Cross the *ropes*, not the hands, and hold down at the silver knots.

- Low Row – the narrow row, ropes crossed x 10
    - Contract and resist, not contract and release – the return isn't a rest; don't flare the ribs
    - Smaller range to regress · pause at end range to advance
- High Row – the wide row, elbows just below shoulder height x 10 (transverse)
    - Elbows lower, smaller range, sit closer to regress · pause at end range to advance
- Single-Arm Row with Rotation, ropes crossed x 8 each side (transverse)
    - High or low, your choice; the ribs turn, the hips stay facing forward – that is what the ball is for
    - Sit closer, smaller rotation, or no rotation to regress · free hand reaches the opposite way to advance
- *Optional:* Shoulder Retractions, ropes uncrossed, straight arms drawing back past the hips x 8
- *Optional:* Reverse Fly, open out x 8 (frontal)
    - Smaller opening, sit closer to regress; skip it with a shoulder flag
    - Palms down and lift into a slight V to advance – open-out is a complete exercise on its own
- Bicep Curl, ropes uncrossed x 10 – elbows lifted just below the shoulders
    - Hold the last curl, then press the arms up overhead x 6
    - Small press to forehead height, or skip the press, to regress · shuffle further from the shoulder rests to advance
- *Optional:* Mountain Climber, straps away, still facing the straps x 10
    - Plank, hands on the frame at the strap end, feet on the carriage – draw both knees in, press back out to a long plank
    - Knees down (kneeling), smaller range to regress · one knee at a time, quicker tempo to advance

One red matches the manual's setting for rows but it is heavy for arm work after Section 1 and the plank block. Set the load with position, not springs: everyone sits closer to the straps and moves back only if the rows feel easy. The heaviest moments are the single-arm row, the Reverse Fly and the overhead press. Shoulders lifting to the ears = shorten the range.

The Mountain Climber is the sixth wrist-loaded exercise – offer fists again before it starts, and a knee pad for anyone taking the kneeling version. All three optionals are your time buffer: skip them all and you are ~2½ minutes early, so hold the cooldown for 8 breaths instead of 5 rather than adding exercises.

> *Pre-cue: "Last press – hold it up there. Now put the straps away and come onto your hands on the frame, feet on the carriage, still facing this way. Footbar stays down, same spring."*

COOLDOWN: 4.5 MIN

Spring: R (unchanged – footbar down)
Static holds only, 5 breaths each, calm voice, minimal cueing, music noticeably down. One Mermaid on the carriage, then everyone steps off and finishes standing. No spring change – we stay on one red.

- Mermaid, side-seated on the carriage, reach up and over x 5 breaths each side
- Step off – stand at the side of the reformer, hand on the frame if balance needs it
- Standing Figure 4, ankle across the opposite thigh, sit the hips back and down, x 5 breaths each side
- Quad stretch, standing – catch the foot behind, tailbone tucked first, x 5 breaths each side
- Tricep stretch, elbow up by the ear, hand down the spine, gentle press, x 5 breaths each side
- Deep breath – arms sweep wide and up on the inhale, float down on the exhale x 3 breaths
- Forward fold – roll down, knees soft, head and arms heavy x 5 breaths
- Swing left to right in the fold, then roll up to stand tall x 20 sec

"Included a cooldown that provided a slow end to class" is its own scored criterion, and a rushed cooldown reads worse than a short one – which is exactly why it is protected. If you arrive here at 40:30 instead of 39:30, drop the tricep stretch. Do not speed up the rest.

CLASS OUTRO: 1 MIN

> *"Beautiful work – that was a big one in forty-five minutes. Take one more breath and notice how different your body feels from when you walked in. If anything felt off, or you want more or less of something next time, come and find me – I'd genuinely rather know. Thanks for moving with me."*

Then stand by the door, make eye contact as people leave, and check in individually – by name – with anyone who flagged an injury at the start. The screening only scores if you close the loop on it at the end.

MUSIC

SEGMENT	BPM	STYLE
Intro & screening	90–100	Warm, low, under your voice
Warm-up	110–118	Building instrumental, clear beat for Prances
Section 1 – Core	100–110	Steady, low vocal – precision-friendly
Section 2a – Legs	122–128	Peak energy, driving
Section 3 – Plank block	112–120	Strong but not frantic – they need to hear you
Section 2b – Legs	122–128	Bring it back up; this is the second-wind moment
Section 4 – Back	108–116	Groove-driven, rhythmic – rows sit on the beat
Cooldown	60–75	Ambient, minimal beat, noticeably quieter

Roughly 11 tracks at 45 minutes. Mark the track change into Section 2b – the lift in energy is what stops the second leg side feeling like a repeat.

SPRINGS AND APPARATUS

RR (warm-up) → **R** (everything else: core / straps, legs, plank block, back, cooldown)
One spring change, well under the maximum of three. One bar change, at 31:30 (bar down entering Section 4), with no spring change attached – the footbar stays up from the warm-up through Section 3 because Section 1 uses it as the target for the leg extensions.

CHANGE	CLOCK	CALL	BAR
1	7:30	"Take one red off – one red only, and that's the only change today. Footbar stays up."	Up
–	31:30	"Footbar down. Spring stays on one red – after this, nothing on your reformer moves again."	Down (bar only)

Trade-offs worth naming – an assessor rewards a stated trade-off and marks down an unexplained one:

- **One change is a deliberate choice.** Every minute not spent on springs goes on movement, and the class never stops for set-up after 7:30. The load is managed with range and position instead of springs. That is the answer if an assessor asks why there is only one change.
- **The warm-up runs on two reds, not three.** Lighter than a heavy footwork setting, and that is the point: the return has to be controlled rather than caught by the spring – "the way back is the work", which is the cue the whole warm-up is built around. It still carries the bridges and the press-out comfortably, and it is a solid load for the single leg extension. Strong regulars slow the return rather than add spring.
- **The only change is the easiest one there is.** RR → R is "take one red off" – nothing to fit, nothing to find, and it happens seated straight after the Roll Up.
- **Section 1 runs on one red, not a blue.** A solid setting for the Hundred, the arm press-down, the leg extensions and the tricep press. It asks more of the shoulders and the back of the arm, so the regressions are smaller arm range and head down, not a lighter spring.
- **The legs and the plank block run on one red, the less stable setting.** A looser carriage makes the standing work (Long Lunge with the ball, Scooter, Flying Lunge) wobblier and asks more of balance and deep core. Regress with range, or ball down and hands on the bar – not by adding spring, which would cost two more changes (on and off again).
- **The plank block carries the leg spring rather than taking its own.** One red makes Long Stretch and Down Stretch harder to control on the way home, and that is the point. Knees down is the first regression, and it keeps the split-leg structure free.
- **Section 4 stays on one red, which is heavy for arm work.** A blue would be more comfortable for the single-arm row, the Reverse Fly and the overhead press, but it would cost a second change. Instead everyone sits closer to the straps, and those three have range-based regressions (the Reverse Fly and the Press Up can be skipped). If the room is mostly beginners or several people flag shoulders, the fallback is a blue at 31:30, done with the bar change – still only two changes.
- **Direction of progression is not universal.** Heavier is harder for the pressing work (footwork, rows); lighter is harder for the balance and stability work (Flying Lunge, Scooter, Long Stretch). Be ready to say this if asked why the springs go *down* for the standing work.

Props. One small soft ball per reformer – held in the arms in the warm-up and the standing work, threaded under the tabletop leg or passed under the thigh, squeezed between the knees in the Bridges and the plank block, held high between the thighs through the back block. Have it on the carriage before class starts. Also: shoulder-rest blocks; a knee pad for Down Stretch and the high kneeling block – offer it at screening; a wedge if anyone flags pregnancy.

PILATES PRINCIPLES

PRINCIPLE	WHERE IT LANDS	WHAT YOU SAY
Breath	Hundred (five in, five out); every cooldown hold	"Breathe wide into the sides of the ribs"
Concentration	Sections 2a/2b unilateral work with the ball pass; Single-Arm Row with Rotation	"One side at a time – all your attention on this leg"
Control	Eccentric return in the Leg Press and the bridge press-out, Long Lunge, Long Stretch	"The way back is the work"
Centering	Every straps exercise in Section 1; the ball squeeze through the plank block	"It starts from the centre, not the limb"
Precision	The ball threaded under the knee and passed under the thigh; the Long Lunge ball pass and Scooter heel raises	"Small and exact beats big and sloppy here"
Flow	Section 4 stays in the straps until the optional Mountain Climber (the only change is uncrossing them); the footbar-facing chain across Sections 2a–2b	Don't say it – demonstrate it by never stopping the class
Whole-body movement	Elephant, Long Stretch, Flying Lunge – legs, spine and arms loaded together	"This is a whole-body exercise, not a leg exercise"

IF YOU ARE RUNNING OVER OR UNDER

Over (most likely). Take it out of Section 4, in this order:

- Drop the optional Mountain Climber
- Drop the optional Reverse Fly
- Drop the optional Shoulder Retractions
- Bicep Curl 10 → 8
- Single-Arm Row with Rotation 8 → 6 each side

That is up to about 3¼ minutes and nobody notices. If you are still over at 40:30, drop the tricep stretch from the cooldown.

Never cut: the second leg side, Down Stretch, the screening, or the outro. Each is either a safety issue, a scored item, or leaves the class visibly unbalanced.

Under. Keep all three optional exercises in, then add reps rather than exercises – the Long Lunge ball-pass hold and the Low Row both take another 4 reps comfortably, and the cooldown holds stretch from 5 breaths to 8 without changing the shape of anything.

ANATOMY AND CUEING – WARM-UP

EXERCISE	MUSCLES CUED	SET-UP CUE	EXECUTION CUE
Leg Press – Pilates V, toes parallel, then balls of the feet	Quadriceps, glutes, hamstrings, gastrocnemius/soleus; the Pilates V adds adductors and deep hip rotators; holding the ball adds shoulder stabilisers	"Balls of the feet, heels touching, toes apart, ball held up over the chest" → "Feet parallel, hip-width"	"Press away, and resist the carriage home – then small pulses, knees soft"
Heel Raises	Gastrocnemius, soleus	"Legs straight, carriage still, ball stays still in the hands"	"Lift the heels, lower slowly – the carriage doesn't move"
Prances	Calves, ankle mobility, alternating hip flexors	"Light on the balls of the feet"	"One heel drops as the other lifts – quick and light"
Single Leg Extension + ball thread	Quadriceps, glutes, hamstrings, calf; glute medius for pelvic control; obliques for the thread	"One foot stays on the bar, other leg to tabletop, ball in the hands – find neutral first"	"Press the carriage out and thread the ball under the tabletop leg – hips stay level, the hip doesn't grip"
Glute Bridge – neutral, articulate, lift & lower	Glute maximus, hamstrings, spinal erectors; the squeeze adds the adductors and pelvic floor	"Heels on the bar, hip-width, ball between the knees, arms long – tuck, arch, settle in the middle"	"Peel up one bone at a time, squeeze the ball at the top and hold the squeeze all the way down – ribs wrap towards the hips, don't thrust the pelvis"
Glute Bridge 2, press out & return + pulses & hold	Hamstrings and glute max holding the hips; quadriceps pressing; adductors on the squeeze; deep core against the moving carriage	"Top of the bridge, ball squeezed"	"Press the carriage away – hips lower an inch – pull it home and they lift. Then park it: pulse, lower ten percent and lift, hold, and roll down"
Pilates Roll Up	Rectus abdominis, transversus, hip flexors; spinal articulation	"Legs long over the footbar, feet flexed, arms reaching up"	"Nod first, then peel off one bone at a time – and lower down the same way"

ANATOMY AND CUEING – CORE, HANDS IN STRAPS

EXERCISE	MUSCLES CUED	SET-UP CUE	EXECUTION CUE
Arm Press Down in straps	Latissimus dorsi, teres major, triceps, lower trapezius; abdominals to hold the ribs	"Straps in hands, arms straight above the shoulders"	"Press long down to the hips, resist back up – ribs stay heavy"
Abdominal Curl in straps	Rectus abdominis, transversus; latissimus dorsi and triceps pressing the arms	"Straps in hands, arms above the shoulders, legs at tabletop"	"Press the arms to the hips and curl up on the same breath – arms stay long"
Curl + Single Leg Extension	Rectus abdominis, transversus, iliopsoas; glute medius and obliques holding the pelvis level	"Curl up and stay up, one leg at a time"	"One leg goes on a journey, the bent knee stays home – the pelvis doesn't rock"
Curl + Double Leg Extension (over / under the bar)	Rectus abdominis, transversus, latissimus dorsi, iliopsoas; adductors if the legs stay together	"Arms long, straps taut, legs to tabletop"	"Curl from the ribs, extend over the bar – under the bar only if the low back stays quiet"
Hold → legs only → Scissors	Rectus abdominis, transversus, iliopsoas, hamstrings (lengthening); pelvic stabilisers	"Curl up, legs extended, arms pressed towards the footbar"	"Hold it still – bend and extend the legs only, then scissor all the way up and all the way down"
Hold → Tricep Press	Triceps brachii under load; lats and lower trapezius holding the shoulder; abdominals holding the curl and the ribs	"Curl held, legs long, arms reaching towards the footbar"	"Only the forearms move – upper arms still, elbows towards the bar, shoulders heavy"
Hold → Flutter Kick	Iliopsoas and quadriceps alternating; rectus abdominis and transversus against the moving legs	"Curl held, both legs long"	"Small and quick, one up one down – the flutter is at the hips, the back stays long"
Hundred	Anterior chain + lateral/thoracic breathing	"Curl up, arms long, legs where you need them"	"Five beats in, five beats out"

ANATOMY AND CUEING – LEGS AND PLANK

EXERCISE	MUSCLES CUED	SET-UP CUE	EXECUTION CUE
Long Lunge + ball pass	Front-leg quadriceps and glute max; back-leg hip flexor lengthening; trunk stabilisers with the hands off the bar	"Front foot planted, back leg long on the carriage, ball in the hands"	"Lunge, then lunge and reach the ball up, then one lunge, one pass under the front thigh – in the hold, only the ball moves"
Scooter (with ball) + heel raises	Glute maximus, hamstrings; standing-leg glute medius and minimus; deep core for pelvic stability	"Back foot against the shoulder rest, standing leg strong, ball held at the chest"	"Press the carriage back, weight in the standing heel – then one scooter, one heel raise, then hold and just lift the heel"
Flying Lunge – knee tuck	Hip flexors, rectus abdominis, shoulder stabilisers, support-leg quads	"Ball down. Hands on the bar, one foot on the carriage"	"Draw the knee in from the deep abdominals, shoulders over the wrists"
Flying Lunge – knee L/R/C	Adds internal and external obliques	"Same shape, the knee now travels"	"Knee to the outside, to the inside, then centre"
Down Stretch (ball)	Spinal erectors, glute max, quadriceps; pectoral opening; adductors on the squeeze	"Kneeling, hands on the bar, ball between the knees, hips forward"	"Press the hips forward, lift the chest – length before extension"
Long Stretch (ball)	Anterior chain, anterior deltoid, serratus, lats; adductors	"Plank position, hands on the bar, feet on the shoulder blocks, ball between the knees"	"One long line from head to heels – move the carriage, not the hips"
Push-up (ball)	Pectorals, triceps, anterior deltoid, serratus, transversus; adductors	"Plank first, ball squeezed, then bend the elbows"	"Elbows wide on a diagonal, chest lowers between the hands, hips stay in line"
Elephant	Hamstrings, deep abdominals, latissimus dorsi, shoulder stabilisers	"Ball down. Hands on the bar, spine rounded, heels down"	"Hinge from the hips – the carriage moves, the spine doesn't"
One-Leg Elephant stretch	Standing-leg hamstrings and calf; glute max of the lifted leg; glute medius for pelvic control; shoulder stabilisers	"Same shape, spine neutral, one leg reaches long behind"	"Hips and shoulders stay square – don't let one shoulder lift as the leg goes back"

ANATOMY AND CUEING – BACK CHAIN AND COOLDOWN

EXERCISE	MUSCLES CUED	SET-UP CUE	EXECUTION CUE
Low Row – narrow (crossed)	Latissimus dorsi, biceps, mid-back	"Ropes crossed, hands at the silver knots, palms facing in"	"Draw the elbows straight back to the waist – contract and resist, not contract and release"
High Row – wide (crossed)	Posterior deltoid, rhomboids, mid and upper trapezius	"Ropes crossed, elbows lifted to just below shoulder height"	"Draw the elbows wide and back – open collarbones, shoulders stay down"
Single-Arm Row with Rotation (crossed)	Lats unilaterally; internal and external obliques; thoracic rotators; adductors holding the ball	"One strap only, tall spine, ball high between the thighs"	"Row, and let the ribcage turn with the arm – squeeze the ball, the hips stay facing forward"
Optional: Shoulder Retractions	Mid and lower trapezius, rhomboids, lats	"Uncross the ropes. Straight arms by your sides, palms forward"	"Draw the arms back past the hips, blades to the midline"
Optional: Reverse Fly (+ V layer)	Posterior deltoid, rhomboids, mid-trap; the V adds lower trap and serratus	"Arms forward at shoulder height, palms facing in"	"Open wide in line with the shoulders – and if it's available, palms down and lift into a V"
Bicep Curl → hold → Press Up (uncrossed)	Biceps brachii, brachialis; the press adds deltoids, triceps, serratus anterior and lower trap	"Hands inside the loops, arms straight at shoulder height, palms to the sky"	"Little fingers to your eyeline, elbows stay lifted – hold the last one, then press overhead, ribs stay down"
Optional: Mountain Climber (facing the straps)	Rectus abdominis, transversus, hip flexors, shoulder stabilisers, serratus anterior, triceps	"Straps away, still facing them. Hands on the frame, feet on the carriage, long plank"	"Shoulders stay over the wrists – draw the knees in from the deep abdominals, hips stay low"
Mermaid	Quadratus lumborum, obliques, intercostals, lats	"Side-seated, one hand down beside you"	"Reach up first, then over – lengthen the ribs apart, open, don't collapse"
Standing Figure 4	Piriformis, deep hip external rotators, glute medius	"Ankle across the opposite thigh, one hand on the frame"	"Sit the hips back and down – let the knee widen"
Standing quad stretch	Rectus femoris, vastus group, iliopsoas	"Catch the foot behind you, knees together"	"Tuck the tailbone, then press the hip forward"
Tricep stretch	Triceps brachii, latissimus dorsi, posterior deltoid	"Elbow up by the ear, hand down the spine"	"Gentle press on the elbow – ribs stay down"
Forward fold → swing	Hamstrings, erector spinae, thoracolumbar fascia	"Knees soft, fold from the hips"	"Head and arms heavy, sway side to side, then roll up"

TEACHING DELIVERY NOTES

- **Holding the room.** The warm-up uses simple, repeated language on purpose – it frees you to make eye contact instead of over-explaining. Learn two or three names in the first two minutes.
- **Cueing and pre-cueing.** At this pace, pre-cueing is what keeps the class from stalling. Pre-cue every position change one exercise early, especially the three big ones: lying → seated at the end of Section 1 (and sitting up for the spring change at the top of the Roll Up before it), putting the ball down before the Flying Lunge (and back between the knees for Down Stretch), and the turn-around plus crossing the ropes at the end of Section 2b. Because the room sets its own springs, call the one change by colour and count – "take one red off, one red only" – demonstrate it on your own reformer, and don't start cueing again until you've scanned the carriages. Keep the language consistent: "carriage goes away", "carriage comes home".
- **Alignment.** Three things to watch all class: hips level in the Single Leg Extension and the Scooter (and feet flaring in the bridges), ribs knitted in the Hundred and Long Stretch, shoulders away from the ears in the whole back block. With the ball in the arms, also watch that the shoulders don't creep up to hold it.
- **Observation.** Section 2b is your window – the exercises are known, so move and watch rather than talk. Scan every set, not just the first rep.
- **Hands-on adjustments.** Highest-value moments: pelvis level in the Scooter, hip squareness in the Flying Lunge, hips staying still in the Single-Arm Row with Rotation, a light hand at the sacrum in the Bridges. Ask before you touch; consent was taken at screening, so use their name.
- **Demonstration.** Fully demonstrate three only – you don't have time for more: the Flying Lunge (orientation is confusing from the floor), the Long Lunge ball pass (so the rhythm of "1 lunge, 1 pass, return" is clear), and crossing the ropes (so nobody rows with them set wrong). Mirror everything else.
- **Motivation and personality.** Sections 2a and 2b are the natural energy windows – humour and encouragement belong there. Drop your tone noticeably at the Mermaid; the contrast is what makes four and a half minutes of cooldown feel like a proper cooldown.
- **Creativity and flow.** Three moments that show deliberate sequencing rather than a list: splitting the legs around the plank block, the Flying Lunge knee pattern growing out of the tuck in the same shape, and the ball as one prop that builds – from a thread and a pass (coordination) in the warm-up and lunges, to a squeeze (adductors and deep core) in the bridges and plank block, to a squeeze held high between the thighs in the rows, where it is what keeps the pelvis square through the rotation. If asked "why this order?", those are your three answers.

DEVIATIONS TO OWN IF ASKED

All deliberate, none accidental:

- **No separate lying lower-body block.** The framework allocates 7 minutes to it; here it is covered by the Bridges in the warm-up, and the time is spent on standing lower body instead. The framework explicitly permits weaving muscle groups through the class rather than blocking them.
- **No dedicated adductor exercise.** Inner-thigh work is covered by the ball squeeze in the Bridges, through the plank block and high between the thighs in the back block, plus the Pilates V Leg Press.
- **No prone work.** Down Stretch carries all the spinal extension – a considered omission given how much plank loading is already in the class.

COVERAGE CHECK AGAINST THE CRITERIA

CRITERION	WHERE IT'S MET
Introduction & screening	Script plus a flag table carried through the class
Pilates principles	All seven mapped to named exercises
Time management	Running clock, two checkpoints, over / under contingencies
Warm-up	5.5 min, dynamic only, all three planes, no static holds
Cooldown	4.5 min, static holds, seated on the carriage to standing
Selection of exercises	Sagittal, frontal and transverse; push and pull; flexion and extension
Layering and modifications	Every exercise has a base plus at least one layer; four progressions are structural
Anatomy	Muscles, set-up cue and execution cue per exercise
Music	BPM per segment
Springs and apparatus	1 spring change, 1 bar change, rope crossing, ball as a prop, trade-offs stated
Class outro	Check-in, feedback invitation, closing the screening loop
Teaching component (all items)	Teaching delivery notes

Exercise selection is the instructor's own. Category names, spring colour / tension codes and the class-length framework follow the taxonomy recorded in AGENTS.md §5. No instructional prose, cue blocks or class plans were copied from the Reformer manual — all cues, scripts, timings, music, layering and sequencing rationale are written for this plan.

NOTES